

Attacking Arguments

As your opponents present their arguments, you must plan how you will destroy them. You must look at what they have said and figure out what you can say to poke holes in each point. And then you must deliver your attacks in a clear, organized manner. It's easy if you just follow the pattern. Try this 4-step refutation method.

The opposition said ...	summarize what the opposition said <u>very briefly</u> – if you spend too long on this, you are just reinforcing the other's side argument and letting the judge hear all about it again.
But	tell them that what the opposition said isn't accurate, or significant, or true etc. – in other words, explain what is wrong with the analysis of the opposition
Because.....	explain WHY it isn't accurate etc. – present your logic and evidence to show WHY it isn't correct – sometimes you will have MORE than one reason for why it isn't accurate. In that case, you may have to divide your attack into subpoints. And if the other side had subpoints, you will need to attack each subpoint separately.
Therefore.....	draw the conclusion – show the judge how this weakens your opponent's case and how it supports your position in the debate.

What's important about the pattern above is that it is organized and clear. Most judges appreciate hearing a well-constructed attack. Think about it from the judge's point of view – which team would you vote for? One team is organized, their arguments are clearly stated, they present evidence in an understandable way, and they precisely tell you why each attack is important to the resolution being debated. The other team jumps all over, doesn't succinctly state their points, doesn't number their subpoints so you can't tell when they have started a new piece of analysis, and never tells why their attack is important to the resolution. The decision is clear!

Remember that each part of your opponent's argument can be attacked:

- Is the **claim** overstated? Does it suffer from a fallacy?
- Do the **warrants** support the claim? Is it logical? What is the quality of the evidence?
- Does the **impact** matter?

On the next page, see this strategy in action. We will use it with the argument on cell phones and see how it might be handled. Remember, this is just a suggestion -- there are many ways to attack a point.

The opposition said....	that cells phones lead teens to risky behaviors, and as their subpoint A says, it often happens while walking and talking on the phone.
But.....	we would argue this: risky behaviors are an accepted part of being a teenager and those risky behaviors will continue even if teens don't have cell phones.
Because.....	Teens are always involved in risky behavior, and as a society we have accepted that risk as part of the teen years and permitted them to do it. A. They can drive though it increases their accidents B. They can play football though it increases their risk for injury. C. They can use the computer though it causes injuries like carpal tunnel
And	Subpoint B on cyberbullying can't be solved through banning cell phone use by teens.
Because.....	kids will be bullied regardless of the cell phone. 56% of students say they have personally felt some sort of bullying at school. The bullying will not stop just because cell phones aren't there.
Therefore.....	we would argue that the Affirmation's claim that cell phones are bad because they lead to risky behavior isn't significant. And furthermore, many of those risky behaviors aren't inherent to the cell phone and will continue with or without the cell phone.